



The burned-out wreckage of British airship *R101* lies in a field outside Beauvais in northern France. Britain's Air Secretary was killed in the crash.

Famous flight

British aviatrix Amy Johnson after her solo flight from England to Australia. Pilots were among the leading celebrities of the time.

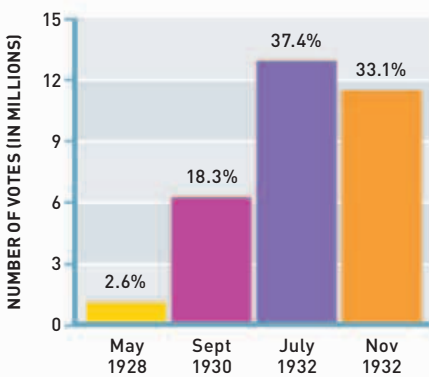
carry the British Secretary of State for Air and other dignitaries from England to India. The badly designed craft only reached northern France, where it crashed in bad weather, killing 48 of the 54 people on board.

By far the worst disaster of 1930, however, was the **collapse of the world economy**. In the US, at the start of the year, most commentators believed that, in the wake of the stock market crash (see 1929), the country was facing a temporary and modest economic downturn. In May, **President Herbert Hoover** (1874–1964) reassured Americans that they had “now passed the worst.” Instead, unemployment continued to rise, bread lines became a common sight, farmers began to go bankrupt in large numbers, and over 1,300 US



banks failed during the year. The US unwisely sought relief for its farmers and unemployed workers through blocking imports. The **Smoot–Hawley Tariff Act**, which became law in June, placed heavy duties on thousands of imported goods. When the US's trading partners retaliated, the world was set on course for a disastrous reduction in overall levels of trade.

In **Germany**, economic crisis triggered political extremism and the **collapse of democratic government**. In March, the governing coalition fell apart because the Social Democrats would not agree to cuts in unemployment benefit. Heinrich Brüning (1855–1970), leader of the Center Party, formed a government without majority support in the Reichstag. He dissolved parliament in July, calling a general election against a background of massive unemployment. Adolf Hitler's Nazi Party mounted a spectacular and violent election campaign, blaming all of Germany's problems on the Versailles Treaty (see 1919). The **Nazis increased their seats** in the Reichstag from 12 to 107, becoming the second largest party in the country. Brüning responded to a polarized Reichstag by ignoring it and



Nazi vote in federal elections 1928–1932
A minority extremist party in 1928, the Nazi party grew to be the largest single party by summer 1932. They peaked at 37.4 per cent of votes cast.

clinging to power, ruling by Emergency Decree.

Many observers outside Germany were disturbed by the growing support for Hitler's aggressive nationalist extremism. France showed its lack of trust in a peaceful future by beginning construction of formidable defensive fortifications along its border with Germany. In the pursuit of absolute security, **the Maginot Line** consumed most of France's defense budget during the 1930s.

South American countries were especially vulnerable to the Depression because of their role as suppliers of food and raw materials to the industrialized US and Europe. Many experienced **political upheavals** as economic conditions worsened. In **Argentina**, a military coup ushered in a decade of political conflict and government corruption. In **Brazil**, an army revolt brought Getúlio Vargas (1882–1954) to power in November. Vargas installed a

populist dictatorship that pushed for the industrialization of Brazil and suppressed political dissent, while introducing social welfare measures for the poor.

In Japan, radical nationalists, including many army and navy officers, believed the answer to **Japan's economic problems** lay in military conquest. The civilian government of prime minister **Osachi Hamaguchi** (1870–1931) outraged them further by seeking cuts in military spending to help offset a budgetary deficit. On November 14, Hamaguchi was shot at Tokyo station by a member of a nationalist secret society. He never recovered, and died nine months later. It was an ominous sign of the Japanese militarists' determination to pursue their own aggressive expansionist policies.

Japanese assassination

Japanese Prime Minister Hamaguchi after being shot by a nationalist extremist at Tokyo station. He died the following year.

